

Toddler Sleep Consultant Scam — Action Checklist

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AUDIT YOUR CONSULTANT EXPERIENCE

- ☐ **Count how many audit questions you answered 'no' to and note that answering 'no' to 3 or more means you received a template instead of personalized advice.:** Count how many audit questions you answered 'no' to and note that answering 'no' to 3 or more means you received a template instead of personalized advice.
- ☐ **Check whether your consultant asked about medical history, feeding schedules, and developmental changes before giving any sleep advice because genuine customization requires understanding your child's full context.:** Check whether your consultant asked about medical history, feeding schedules, and developmental changes before giving any sleep advice because genuine customization requires understanding your child's full context.
- ☐ **Verify that your consultant explained why their method works specifically for toddlers rather than just citing generic infant sleep principles that don't apply to children over 18 months.:** Verify that your consultant explained why their method works specifically for toddlers rather than just citing generic infant sleep principles that don't apply to children over 18 months.
- ☐ **Confirm that your consultant provided a clear protocol for what to do if your child's sleep worsened, not just instructions for the ideal scenario where everything goes smoothly.:** Confirm that your consultant provided a clear protocol for what to do if your child's sleep worsened, not just instructions for the ideal scenario where everything goes smoothly.

UNDERSTAND TODDLER DEVELOPMENT

- ☐ **Accept that by 18 months your toddler understands object permanence and knows you are choosing to leave them alone, which makes cry-it-out fundamentally different than with infants.:** Accept that by 18 months your toddler understands object permanence and knows you are choosing to leave them alone, which makes cry-it-out fundamentally different than with infants.

- ☐ **Recognize that separation anxiety peaking around 18 months is a developmental stage rooted in attachment awareness that should not be treated as a behavior to be trained away.:** Recognize that separation anxiety peaking around 18 months is a developmental stage rooted in attachment awareness that should not be treated as a behavior to be trained away.

- ☐ **Understand that toddlers form emotional memories and may develop a conditioned fear response to the bedroom or crib after prolonged crying episodes during sleep training.:** Understand that toddlers form emotional memories and may develop a conditioned fear response to the bedroom or crib after prolonged crying episodes during sleep training.

- ☐ **Stop comparing toddler sleep methods to infant methods because the developmental contexts are entirely different and what works for a 6-month-old may harm a 22-month-old.:** Stop comparing toddler sleep methods to infant methods because the developmental contexts are entirely different and what works for a 6-month-old may harm a 22-month-old.

APPLY EVIDENCE-BASED STRATEGIES

- ☐ **Extend wake windows to 4-6 hours of awake time before your toddler's longest sleep period since the 2-3 hour windows used for infants no longer apply after 18 months.:** Extend wake windows to 4-6 hours of awake time before your toddler's longest sleep period since the 2-3 hour windows used for infants no longer apply after 18 months.

- ☐ **Try a later bedtime if your toddler is in an overtiredness spiral since an earlier bedtime can cause a cortisol spike that makes falling asleep harder, not easier.:** Try a later bedtime if your toddler is in an overtiredness spiral since an earlier bedtime can cause a cortisol spike that makes falling asleep harder, not easier.

- ☐ **Fill your child's emotional tank by spending device-free time together in the hour before bed as a daily practice, not a reward for going to sleep, to reduce overnight escalation.:** Fill your child's emotional tank by spending device-free time together in the hour before bed as a daily practice, not a reward for going to sleep, to reduce overnight escalation.

- ☐ **Rule out medical issues and underlying conditions before starting any sleep intervention since pain, reflux, or developmental concerns can mimic or worsen sleep problems.:** Rule out medical issues and underlying conditions before starting any sleep intervention since pain, reflux, or developmental concerns can mimic or worsen sleep problems.